Within a week, Beijing controlled large parts of what India considered its territory, which Indian troops had been unable to defend. During a brief pause in fighting, China put forth and India rejected a proposal that would have accepted Chinese gains in the western sector. In mid-November, the lull ended with a Chinese offensive in the eastern sector, where Chinese troops overran Indian positions. The Indian military position was dire in both the east and the west, with eastern India left extremely vulnerable. Nehru sought expanded US military assistance. Before most of this assistance could be delivered, however, the war ended when China unilaterally declared a ceasefire on November 21, keeping its territorial gains in the western sector, while restoring the status quo in the eastern sector.[239]

During the war, it became clear that India could not count on the Soviet Union. While earlier Moscow had professed neutrality, Khrushchev eventually gave China what Srinath Raghavan has called "a wink and a nod."[240] Once the crisis was underway, the Soviet Union tilted toward China. The US, on the other hand, supported India. Before the war, when Kaul had reportedly suggested at a meeting on October 11 that India look to the US for significant military assistance, Nehru had rejected his advice. At that time, neither the scale of the war nor the lack of Soviet support had been evident. Moreover, while Indian policymakers had been aware of military "difficulties,"[241] at that point they had not thought India was facing an existential threat. As of October 18, Nehru had even "discounted" the significance of some key clashes.[242]

Until October 25, the US embassy in India also believed that China had "limited objectives" in the east. It was only on that day, with the reported fall of the town of Tawang south of the McMahon Line, that Galbraith said that the US must consider if Beijing had "graver ambitions." He interpreted the continued lack of a formal request for US aid as driven by hope that Moscow would restrain Beijing, as well as by Krishna Menon's reluctance. When Galbraith met with Indian finance minister Morarji Desai and foreign secretary M. J. Desai on October 24 and 25, however, both indicated that a request was "inevitable and imminent." The ambassador wanted Washington to be prepared to respond promptly in order to assure India, deter China, and create goodwill toward the US. He suggested contingency planning to supply India.[243]